CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Jewish Attitudes Facing Antisemitism: A Gender Analysis

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Using feminist theories of difference and identity, we can analyze modern Jewish dilemmas, in particular, aspects related to Jewish attitudes to, and perceptions of, antisemitism, including assimilation, separatism, Jewish invisibility, self-hatred, hostility, and solidarity. Recent events in Israel and the Diaspora offer an opportunity to look at the roles and attitudes of women in times of crisis.

JEWISH "ASSIMILATION": PROTECTION AGAINST ANTISEMITISM OR A BETRAYAL?

"Jewish difference," "Jewish invisibility," and the idea of "Jewish power," have served throughout history as grounds for antisemitism. While some criticized the Jews for their separatism, others feared the erasing of Jewish difference, and noted the difficulty of actually identifying this Jewish difference. Thus, we find that the modern assimilated Jew, who looks like his non-Jewish neighbors, may still experience anti-Jewish prejudice.

Here is the main difference between antisemitism and racism: in general, hatred of the foreigner recedes with the disappearance of difference. In the case of antisemitism, it sometimes increased with the assimilation of the Jew. Invisibility creates a phantasm, and an abstract image of the Jew.[1]

In a beautiful text by French philosopher Vladimir Jankelevich entitled "Ressembler dissembler" (Resembling dissembling, 1984), he notes a temptation he considers as specific to Jews: the need "to look like everybody," to distinguish oneself not at all from the attitude of the majority, from those who surround us, to get lost in them, and not draw their attention. This need to go incognito, which he names "the phobia of the difference" is, as he said, a fundamental element of Jewish existence.

Jankelevich points out that while trying to assimilate to the others, the Jewish man feels "remorse of the neglected difference: because of his

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